



**East West University
Research Proposal**

Effects of Ride-Sharing Employment on Educational Outcomes: Balancing Work and Study for Private University Student Drivers in Dhaka

Submitted by:

Irfan Ahmed

Bachelors in Social Science (Economics)

Submitted to:



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Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Background of the research

In recent years, ride-sharing platforms such as Uber and Pathao have transformed the urban transportation landscape in Dhaka, while simultaneously creating new income-generating opportunities within the gig economy. This digital shift has changed the modes of work experiences to match what today is available as an app-based flexibility, which has proven particularly attractive to segments of the youth population, and especially students of private universities, to earn money through ride-sharing. The characteristics of: flexible scheduling, low barrier of entry and immediate cash provided student who typically cannot finance their education with a source of income (*Alam et al., 2022*). Thus, the ride-sharing economy in Dhaka has become an important livelihood strategy amid young gig workers and represents a socio-economic phenomenon that requires more attention from academic researcher perspective.

A growing number of students enrolled in private universities across Dhaka are now participating in ride-sharing services to offset tuition costs, daily expenses, and support their families. This aligns with findings in other areas of the world where students in the gig economy seek to reduce their financial burden (*Aziz et al., 2024*). In the Bangladeshi context, Shahin (*et al. 2018*) highlight that much of this work situation arises from a lack of access to scholarships and student loans which forces students to find part-time or informal work. However, balancing work with education is difficult in any setting, especially with the level of academic stress. While gig work might help relieve the financial stress, it may debilitate students from academic involvement, class attendance, and study time.

International research showed that work undertaken during higher education can foster employability, but also raise issues about the trade-off between work and academic performance (*Giampiero Passaretta & Moris Triventi, 2015*). In the case of ride-sharing work in Dhaka, where hours are very irregular, and work demands can be physically straining, it could lead to fatigue, stress, and a diminished academic focus through the dual pressures on student drivers to earn money but also value their education. As the gig economy continues to grow in urban Bangladesh, understanding how students manage the trade-off between work which can exert demands on many levels against their university education is essential. This research therefore seeks to examine the implications of ride-sharing employment, among private university students, in Dhaka. It aims to

explore how their educational trajectories are shaped by their engagement in gig work (*such as ride-sharing*), and how the balance between financial necessity and academic aspiration is managed over time.

1.2 Problem Statement

Although the increase of ride-sharing services such as Uber and Pathao in Dhaka has provided students with new income-generating opportunities, in academic research there is an apparent gap regarding the implications of this work on student life in particular academic performance, mental health, and long-term educational success. While part-time work of university students has been studied in various national and international contexts, limited work has focused on the ride-sharing sector in Dhaka, and the context-specific issues that arise in this circumstance, specific to student drivers. For instance, *Akter et al. (2019)* investigated the relationship of part-time work and academic outcomes, however, not on the gig-based ride-sharing model which frequently involves physically strenuous activity and extended periods of separation from peers and academic environments. Therefore, the current literature does not provide sufficient detail of the potential ways in which the rigid and often physically demanding time frame of ride-sharing work can affect a student's ability to concentrate, attend class and achieve academic success.

This gap is particularly concerning because many students from private universities in Dhaka engage in gig work not out of preference, but out of financial necessity. The lack of institutional supports for students, such as scholarships or low-interest student loans, pushes students towards informal gigs (*Shahin 2018*), but without research on longitudinal outcomes, universities and policymakers could find it difficult to develop systems that weigh students' economic needs with their academic progression and mental health. While international research (*Passaretta and Triventi 2015*) notes mixed outcomes of student work on future careers, Dhaka's particular challenges (*its congested road system, high educational costs, and largely unregulated gig economy*) do warrant individually based study. Thus, unless specific research is conducted, the academic, emotional, and future career-related consequences associated with ride-sharing work of students would remain overlooked.

1.3 Research problem

While ride-sharing provides a flexible source of income for private university students in Dhaka, it also raises concerns about negative effects on education. Existing research on student work in Bangladesh primarily focuses on students' level of engagement with traditional part-time jobs, but there is little attention to the demands of ride-sharing—like unpredictable hours, mental or physical stress, gig-based nature of work, etc. The lack of focused research, therefore, inadvertently hampers understanding of how ride-sharing that not only affects [students'] academic performance, but also their mental health and ability to graduate on time. Given the rapid proliferation of ride-sharing services in Dhaka, it would be prudent to investigate the potential trade-offs that arise when students engage in such work during their tertiary education. A clearer understanding of these dynamics would allow for the development of more informed institutional policies and student support mechanisms that address the dual demands of **earning** and **learning**.

1.4 Research Question

1. How does ride-sharing work impact the academic performance of private university students in Dhaka?

1.5 Research Objectives

1. To examine the relationship between ride-sharing work hours and students' academic performance
2. To assess whether engagement in ride-sharing delays or hinders graduation
3. To estimate the short-term and long-term academic and financial trade-offs of participating in ride-sharing work

1.6 Research Hypothesis

Students who work more than 5 hours per day in ride-sharing exhibit significantly lower academic performance due to increased stress and reduced study time.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Part-Time Employment and Academic Performance in Bangladesh

A 2019 study by Akter, Uddin and Jakaria on 108 undergraduate students at Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University (HSTU), Dinajpur, analyzed the effect of part-time work on Cumulative Grade Point Average (CGPA). They employed OLS regressions and showed that part-time job participation and intensity of hours are both statistically significant, showing a negative relation with CGPA, where working students had, on average, 0.153 lower CGPA, and each additional week of part-time working, reduced CGPA by 0.021 points (*Akter et al., 2019*). The findings provide an example of a leisure–study trade-off and demonstrate that some employment time is likely to have a negative effect on engagement with their education, in the specific context of this research.

2.2 University Students’ Understanding and Perceptions of the Gig Economy

Uchiyama et al. (2025) examine Malaysian undergraduates’ understanding and views of the gig economy through focus-group interviews with students studying labor economics. Three main themes were identified: the potential flexibility and competitiveness of an open market; acceptance of gig work as a form of freelancing; and recognition that the type of labor can take on many forms besides full-time employment. Despite the growing companies providing various task-based gig platforms, participants were not willing to engage in gig work because they felt their skills would be mismatched and preferred traditional pathways to career outcomes. The authors advocated for curricular and policy change to position these youth for shifts in labor developments.

2.3 Work Experience during Higher Education and Post-Graduation Outcomes

The comparative analysis of four European countries (Germany, Italy, Norway and Spain) completed by Passaretta and Triventi (2015) shows that student work—especially when aligned with the degree a student is completing—provides significant additional benefits in graduate labor market outcomes. Specifically, Passaretta and Triventi show that irrespective of type of work undertaken during tertiary education, in both Italy and Spain, student work enhances the employability of graduates and reduces the risk of underemployment or unemployment, while work related to a study program reduces the possibility of returning to study as a result of skill mismatches (*Passaretta & Triventi, 2015*). In contrast, the benefits of student work are smaller in

Germany and insignificant in Norway, demonstrating the importance of institutional contexts to the benefits of student work.

2.4 The Gig Economy's Role in Career Development in Bangladesh

Mimi and Mani (2024) examine how digital platforms are reforming career trajectories for Bangladeshi university students and recent graduates. Based on surveys and interviews with 100 gig workers, they explain that 66 percent of student gig workers see gig work before graduation as a fast way to gain practical experience, and 61 percent anticipate that gig work will improve their career chances. However, there are substantial barriers, especially related to the lack of formal recognition for gig workers and social protection (*Mimi & Mani, 2024*). This tension—opportunity versus precarity—frames the context for student ride-share workers, who may negotiate between earning and their education.

2.5 Research Gap: Ride-Sharing Employment and Educational Outcomes

While the literature highlights both the academic costs of part-time work (*Akter et al., 2019*) and the career advantages of structured work experience (*Passaretta & Triventi, 2015*), as well as students' perceptions of gig work (*Uchiyama et al., 2025*) and its contribution to their career development (*Mimi & Mani, 2024*), there has not been a study examining how ride-sharing employment specifically impacts the academic outcomes of private-university student drivers in Dhaka. In light of ride-sharing's particular flexibility and mechanical management, it is important to understand how these drivers navigate competing academic and gig work responsibilities, and whether the ride-sharing context exacerbates or alleviates the trade-offs identified in the literature on part-time work.

Chapter 3: Research Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study utilizes a quantitative, cross-sectional research design to examine the impact of ride-sharing work hours on academic performance of private university students in Dhaka. The main hypothesis to be explored is that students who work more than five hours a day through ride-sharing activities show trend towards low academic performance possibly because of time and stress cited by most drivers. To test the main hypothesis, the study draws on primary survey data

from a sample of 40 student drivers. The cross-sectional design facilitates a correlational analysis, as it aims to identify the statistical relationships between the **intensity of the work (the independent variable)** and **academic performance (the dependent variable)**. To isolate this relationship, the model also controls for key confounding variables such as stress related to income and health.

3.2 Data Collection

The primary data for this research was collected through a structured survey of private university students who were actively engaged in ride-sharing companies (*Uber and Pathao*). The sampling procedure used selective sampling where potential participants were engaged on-site throughout several locations in Dhaka city. The survey measured a number of variables which would align with the broader research objectives.

The demographic section of the survey accounted for the basic background information including age, gender, university and major.

Work variables included average daily hours worked as a ride-share driver, number of days in a week worked, income range and platform(s) used in working as a ride-share driver.

Academic variables included self-reported influences of working as a ride-share driver affecting academic performance with any changes in grades, disruptions to study time, incidence of missing classes or examinations and whether the students had ever considered dropping out of university for work reasons.

Stress and health measures as part of the survey included physical and mental fatigue, sleep disturbances and health complaints which could be associated with long work hours.

3.3 Sampling Strategy

The participants for this study were 40 male students from 15 different private universities in Dhaka. Delivery riders were selected if they engaged in continuous work (*at least three months*) in ride-sharing in order to analyze their lived experience of dealing with the challenge of combining study with paid work, with the minimum threshold of three months was employed to ensure participants had adequate exposure to the (job) challenges of ride-sharing. The male only sample reflects the male dominated ride-sharing work force in Dhaka and limited conclusions can

be drawn for female students who work in this sector, given their underrepresentation in this sample.

3.4 Variables

The primary focus of the study is the number of hours spent working in ride-sharing per day as the independent variable. For analysis, this can be categorized into two groups: students working **more than five hours per day** and those working **five or fewer hours**. This cut-off is based on previous findings (*Akter et al., 2019*) that suggest academic trade-offs become more pronounced beyond certain daily working hours.

The dependent variables could consist of a variety of measurements regarding academic performance. First, self-reported academic changes rated on an ordinal scale: “Significant Drop,” “Minor Drop,” “Same,” “Minor Improvement,” and “Significant Improvement.”

Academic engagement will be measured by indicators such as number of missed classes or exams and measures of the extent through which any study time has been affected through commitments to ride-sharing.

The model includes relevant control variables in order to help limit the impacts of hours worked on student academic performance trigger. Income ranges, physical impact and mental impact of working, year of study, and amounts spent on personal education expenses are included to account for early factors that may have influenced not only the need to work in the ride-sharing industry, but also any previous academic outcomes.

3.5 Data Analysis

The analysis will begin with descriptive statistics, in order to summarize important characteristics of the sample (*demographics, work patterns and self-reported academic outcomes*). This step helps contextualize the data and identify initial trends.

For inferential analysis, chi-square tests will be employed to examine whether there is a relationship between daily ride-share hours (**>5 hours vs. ≤5 hours**) and academic outcomes. This test will assess whether differences in academic performance between groups are statistically significant.

Ordinal logistic regression could also be used to analyze the relationship between work hours and reported changes in academic performance, while controlling for factors such as income and health. This allows for a more precise estimation of the effect of work intensity.

Lastly, qualitative responses collected through open-ended survey questions undergo thematic coding. Qualitative responses indicated numerous areas for inquiry including personal challenges student drivers faced and recommendations for improvement. The qualitative responses will add depth to the quantitative findings.

Chapter 4: Theoretical Framework

This study hypothesizes that students who participate in ride-sharing for more than five hours a day, are likely to experience substantially lower academic performance characterized by suboptimal academic outcomes. This decline could be attributed due to increased stress and diminished study time. The hypothesis is grounded in a rational cost-benefit trade-off framework, where financial pressures are thought to lead students to prioritize current income over long-term academic and economic benefits.

To analyze this behavior, a dynamic cost-benefit logic model could be utilized to account for the time-dependent trade-offs made by students who are simultaneously enrolled in private universities and engaged in ride-sharing work.

The educational and financial trade-offs may be expressed as follows:

Equation (1):

$$GPA(H) \downarrow \Rightarrow T(GPA) \uparrow \Rightarrow D = C \times S$$

Where,

H: The total weekly hours worked in ride-sharing

GPA(H): GPA, which is assumed to be a negative function of H

T(GPA): Graduation time, which is assumed to increase as GPA declines (↑)

D: additional tuition fees due to delayed graduation

C: Cost per semester course

S: additional semester(s) needed due to GPA decline

As hours spent ride-sharing increase, it is assumed that the amount of time and energy devoted to academic work is reduced; this should result in a decline in **GPA**. As **GPA** decreases, we could also expect a longer graduation period, which increases total tuition paid **D**. Thus, the idea could be theoretically formalized as: hours worked daily, relate to poorer academic performance via time and stress-induced constraints.

To explore the long-term financial implications of this decision, the logic is extended using a Net Present Value (**NPV**) model:

Equation (2):

$$NPV = (I \times n) - [(D + W \times m) \times (1 + r)^m]$$

Where,

NPV: Net Present Value of the ride-sharing decision

I: monthly income generated from ride-sharing

n: number of months worked

D: additional tuition cost (*as derived from Equation 1*)

W: monthly wage from a post-graduation career

m: number of months of delayed entry into full-time employment

r: discount rate representing the time value of money

While $(I \times n)$ provides the immediate liquidity associated with ride-sharing, deciding to do ride-sharing will result in longer graduation (**m**), higher tuition costs (**D**), and deferred access to post-graduation income $(W \times m)$. According to the hypothesis, if $NPV < 0$, it can be concluded that excessive work hours (*especially beyond the 5-hour mark*) not only hinder academic performance but also impose long-term financial costs.

To further illustrate the weight of this trade-off, a final ratio is introduced:

Equation (3):

$$DR = \frac{D + W \times m}{I \times n}$$

Where:

DR: Destruction Ratio, defined as the ratio of future financial loss to present income

A **DR** > 1 implies that the long-term financial losses (*which include delayed wages and additional tuition costs*) outweigh the earnings from ride-sharing. In this scenario, the work choice can be interpreted as behaving in a financially destructive way. The model hypothesis is further supported in light of this consideration when noting that students who worked beyond manageable hours were likely inflicting disproportional academic and financial harms.

Through this theoretical framework, student ride-sharing is framed as an intertemporal trade-off that, while appearing rational in the short term, is found to carry long-run academic and financial disadvantages. By framing the hypothesis through a formal model, it could be shown that working long hours (*i.e. more than 5 hours per day*) are associated with lower GPA outcomes caused by stress and reduced study time. These effects are shown to translate into **delayed graduation and forgone future earnings**, an outcome especially concerning in the context of high-cost private education systems in Dhaka city.

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